



BSc. Hons in Ethical Hacking & Cybersecurity

ST4019CMD The Ethics and Legal Framework of Cyber Security

Softwarica College of IT & E-Commerce

Submission Date: July, 2026

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Abstract

Cybersecurity is not just a technical issue anymore; it's becoming a legal, ethical, leadership and personal professional identity issue. This report is a compilation of four interrelated reports on aspects of that reality from various perspectives: Comparative Cyber Law in Nepal and UK, Ethics of AI-based Threat Detection, Cybersecurity Governance and Leadership, and a personal reflection on professional development. It tests the strength of law, ethics and leadership in real-world incidents such as TalkTalk, hack of the Nepal Police website, Equifax, Colonial Pipeline and SolarWinds, then offers an integrated governance policy for a multinational organisation and does some soul searching about the skills the cybersecurity professional requires to operate responsibly. Combined, the report says: "The best cybersecurity requires not only solid technical barriers but also good law, ethical judgment, and responsible leadership.

Introduction

Cybersecurity is now under the nose of nearly every facet of modern organisations and governments, and the ramifications of getting it wrong extend more than just to a technical outage. This report brings together four pieces of work where each examined a different facet of the problem: the laws that ought to regulate cyberspace, the ethics that ought to inform the technology that protects it, the leadership that determines the way organisations react when things go wrong, and the personal skills a cybersecurity practitioner requires for operating responsibly in all of this.

The first section compares the regulatory systems of Nepal and the United Kingdom which are very different stages of development on the basis of two actual breaches the 2025 Nepal Police website breach and the 2015 TalkTalk breach. The second part shifts from law to ethics, addressing the challenges of bias and privacy considerations in AI threat detection, and examining them using both utilitarian and Rawlsian approaches. The third section pivots to governance and leadership, comparing the weak actions taken by Equifax and Colonial Pipeline to the open and clear actions taken by Microsoft in response to SolarWinds, and offers a proposed integrated governance policy. The last module is a personal perspective on three essential professional skills: threat intelligence, ethical decision-making and policy development.

When read together, these four sections convey the same fundamental message in different ways: Cybersecurity is not just about technical controls, it's about law, ethics, and leadership too.

Task 1: Comparative Cybersecurity Legal Frameworks and Global Jurisprudence

1.2 Comparative Analysis of Legal Frameworks

1.2.1 Nepal: Electronic Transactions Act 2063 and the Proposed IT Bill 2024

A reasonable first step in Nepal was to make a statutory recognition of electronic records and digital signatures in the Electronic Transactions Act 2063 (ETA 2063) which also criminalised offences like unauthorized access and posting of illegal information online ([Radiant Chartered Accountants](#), n.d.; [Law Imperial](#), n.d.). Its provisions are, however, not specific, do not cover new forms of cybercrime and are virtually silent on data protection and critical infrastructure. The proposed IT Bill 2024 proposes to bridge this with the introduction of a National Cyber Security Centre, a requirement to obtain licensing for providers, and the protection of critical infrastructure, but it is unclear what is meant by the term “critical” infrastructure and the requirement to report is inconsistent. ([R.A. & Associate](#), n.d.).

1.2.2 United Kingdom: Computer Misuse Act 1990, Data Protection Act 2018, and GDPR

There are laws in the UK and regulations based on the EU's previous laws, including GDPR, which will still apply in the UK in a UK specific format following Brexit. Unauthorised access and disruption of computer systems is criminalised under the Computer Misuse Act 1990 which continues to be the basic legislation for the prosecution of hacking. The Data Protection Act 2018 has been introduced to support

the GDPR and aims to set a high standard for fairness, transparency and accountability and ensure enforceable rights for individuals with regards to their data ([DLA Piper, n.d.](#)).

1.2.3 Addressing Key Cybersecurity Domains

Cybercrime

Both Nepal's ETA 2063 and the UK's CMA 1990 Criminalize cybercrime. However, the UK law is more updated compared to that of Nepal. Besides, Nepal's proposed IT Bill 2024 seeks to promote and enforce cybercrime to enhance security against cyber-attack.

Data Protection

The UK has better data protection laws, such as DPA 2018 and GDPR, compared to Nepal's ETA 2063. Even though the IT Bill 2024 propose some data protection provisions, there is a need for improved guidelines on processing personal data from other jurisdictions.

Critical Infrastructure Security

The UK possesses advanced regulator framework regarding critical infrastructure. The IT Bill 2024 is a positive step forward, but Nepal Still needs clear guidelines and stronger provisions to better protect its critical infrastructure.

Digital Civil Rights

The UK better protects its citizens digital civil rights, compared to Nepal. The former offers more comprehensive data privacy and data protection laws. On the other hand, Nepal needs to develop better legal provisions to enhance the security of its citizens data, especially personal data, including information transmitted across borders.

1.3 International Comparison and Gap Assessment

International initiatives, such as Budapest convention and OECD Digital Security Guidelines contribute to the harmonization of cyber laws among countries. The Budapest convention serves as a framework for international cooperation to combat computer related crimes. The OECD Guidelines push for a risk-based approach to digital security, promoting a broader culture of responsibility and safety.

Nepal's ETA 2063 falls short of these standards in several ways:

- Outdated Cybercrime Laws: Nepal ETA 2063 has vague cybercrime definition and should be update to address emerging threats
- Weak Data Protection: Strengthen privacy like the GDPR to better protect personal data.
- Critical Infrastructure: Develop explicit regulation for securing critical infrastructure.
- International Cooperation: Create policies that facilitate international collaboration on cybercrime investigations.

1.4 Case Studies: When Law Struggled

1.4.1 Nepal: Struggle with Emerging Cybercrime and Digital Evidence

There have been only few confirmed cybercrime prosecutions in Nepal, partly because ETA 2063 was not practical enough to prosecute cyber criminals. Technology has been advancing so rapidly making existing laws and computer forensic science out of date. This was demonstrated when an unknown group of hackers attacked the Nepal Police website in 2025 and exposed details of millions of records on Nepal citizens, an unauthorized access to the database which showed how vulnerable Nepal was to such cybercrimes ([CyberAlert Nepal, n.d.](#); [OnlineKhabar, 2024](#); [Kathmandu Post, 2023](#)).

1.4.2 United Kingdom: The Talk Talk Data Breach (2015) and the Data Protection Act

The TalkTalk data breach that occurred in October 2015 demonstrates how consumer data was not protected by the previous UK data protection laws. Attackers used the vulnerability from SQL injection in the old webpages, revealing personal and banking details of over 150,000 users ([Wikipedia, n.d.](#)).

The ICO's investigation found that TalkTalk hadn't fixed old-fashioned software or properly monitored its systems for weaknesses ([Information Commissioner's Office, n.d.](#)). As a result, the company was fined a record £400,000 for breaching the Data

Protection Act 1998 by failing to secure customer data adequately ([The Guardian, 2016](#)).

The failures were layered:

- **Neglected legacy systems:** The breach traced back to systems from an old purchase that TalkTalk hadn't tied-down or even recognized were still active. This exposed a real gap in accountability for inherited infrastructure.
- **Poor security hygiene:** Old-fashioned software and a lack of active monitoring showed basic cybersecurity practices weren't being followed, even though SQL injection is a well-known threat.
- **Damaged public trust:** The breach badly hurt TalkTalk's reputation and raised wider doubts about how seriously telecom companies were taking data security.

This case helped push the UK toward stronger standards, feeding directly into the stricter DPA 2018 and GDPR that followed. The fine, hefty for its time, also made clear that ignoring cybersecurity has real financial costs.

Task 2: Ethical Dilemmas in Disruptive Cybersecurity Technologies

2.2 Technology: AI-Based Threat Detection

AI threat detection leverages machine learning algorithms to examine network traffic, user activity, and system logs for any patterns that deviate from the norm, including zero-day attacks ([Interface Magazine, 2024](#)). The fact that it's based on large amounts of data and the use of “black box” algorithms brings into real question how decisions are made.

2.3 Ethical Dilemmas

2.3.1 Dilemma 1: Bias, Discrimination, and False Positives

Cybersecurity AI systems can introduce biases that result from the data they have been trained on, such as a model that is more likely to detect suspicious activity or

traffic from certain groups or regions of users than others. This increases the number of false positives, the time spent trying to catch up with them and the judgment of individuals and organizations ([CEBRI, n.d.](#))

The dilemma: adopt a very successful AI system that is being applied in a way that is unfair to some groups, or a less effective AI but more equitable for those groups?

2.3.2 Dilemma 2: The Erosion of Privacy for Enhanced Security

However, AI threat detection is only effective when it is continuously monitoring user activity, communications and network traffic to determine what is normal and what is not. Such constant surveillance is bound to clash with people's right to privacy ([Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy, n.d.](#)).

The question is whether it's ethical to constantly monitor all users to detect threats, sacrificing privacy for overall security, or if giving them privacy prevails even if it means more attacks will be successful?

2.4 Ethical Evaluation

2.4.1 Utilitarianism

Utilitarianism is about the consequences of actions, and the best action is the one that will make the most people the most happy. From a cybersecurity standpoint, if an AI system successfully wards off a large-scale ransomware attack on a hospital, but it occasionally produces false positives, then it is ethical. But rule utilitarianism also calls for the need for fairness and public trust not to be sacrificed over time. ([Quora, 2017](#)).

Utilitarian considerations might support some level of surveillance to avert grave cyberattacks and safeguard society. While there may be a net loss of individual privacy, there is also a net gain in the public's safety and from the reduction of large scale harm.

2.4.2 Rawlsian Justice

John Rawls's theory of justice, especially the "veil of ignorance," asks us to design rules without knowing our own place in society our race, class, or whether we'd be

a typical user or a flagged suspect. It centers on fairness and protecting those worst off ([PubMed Central, 2024](#); [Springer Link, 2023](#)).

- **Evaluating Bias (Dilemma 1):** Rawlsian Perspective biased AI is unfair because no one would choose to live in a society where they could be treated unfairly without knowing their circumstances. The Difference Principle that Rawls states that inequality is only allowable if it is beneficial to the least advantaged, means that AI that discriminates against certain groups is not justifiable.
- **Evaluating Privacy vs. Security (Dilemma 2):** Rawls argues that privacy is a right which cannot be traded for greater security. A fair surveillance system should be based on transparent and clear rules and principles, and it should be well overseen, preventing security and personal privacy from being undermined, rather than accepting mass surveillance.

2.5 Real-World Application: AI in Corporate Surveillance

Imagine that an organization is using AI technology to monitor its employees' email and access to different parts of the building in order to ensure that no one is stealing any information. While this may improve security, some employees may see it as an invasion of their privacy. One way to fix this would be to have a system where employees are notified of any monitoring and have a way to appeal if they feel that they are being wrongly accused.

Task 3: Cybersecurity Governance, Leadership, and Policy Framework Development

3.2 Leadership Strengths and Weaknesses

3.2.1 The Anatomy of Weak Leadership: Equifax and Colonial Pipeline

The 2017 data breach at Equifax, concerning the private information of 147 million individuals, was triggered by the deliberate negligence of the board member who failed to address a recognized vulnerability in their security system in a timely manner. This, among other factors, led to the loss of public confidence in the company. In turn, the ransomware attack on Colonial Pipeline was attributed to a

single compromised virtual private network (VPN) that had authentication mechanisms not protected by multifactor authentication. Both case highlight the inadequate cyber risk management practice and response strategies of the companies involved. ([Huntress, 2025](#)) ([Department of Energy, n.d.](#); [Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency, 2023](#)).

3.2.2 The Anatomy of Strong Leadership: Microsoft and SolarWinds

Microsoft's response to the SolarWinds attack (2020-2021) was strong. This wasn't an incident that the company covered up, but one which it was open about, shared threat intelligence and collaborated on enhancing cyber security. It was clear, focused on the wider community and showed a mature and responsible approach to incident response ([Microsoft, 2020a](#); [Microsoft, 2020b](#); [House Committee on Homeland Security, 2021](#)).

3.2.3 The Decisive Moments

Strong Leadership is demonstrated by dealing cybersecurity threats before they occur through measure such as patching and multifactor authentication and being clear about incidents after they occur. Poor leadership is demonstrated by treating cybersecurity not as a priority business issues, but rather as an IT concern. On the other hand, good leadership realize that cybersecurity threats pose serious liability concerns for the firm.

3.3 Integrated Cybersecurity Ethics and Governance Policy

This policy applies to a multinational organization operating in Nepal, the UK, and the EU. It assure orders with Nepal's ETA 2063 (and the upcoming IT Bill 2024), the UK's DPA 2018, and the EU's GDPR, while arranginf with frameworks like ISO/IEC 27001 and NIST CSF.

3.3.1 Policy Statement and Scope

This policy sets out the governance structure and ethical standards for protecting the organization's information assets. It covers all employees, contractors, and third-party vendors across every jurisdiction the company operates in Nepal, the UK, and the EU.

3.3.2 Core Principles

Three principles hook of the policy: **Privacy by Design** (GDPR Art. 25), building security into systems from the outset; **Data Minimization** (GDPR Art. 5 / ISO 27001), collecting only what is necessary; and **Least Privilege** (NIST CSF PR.AC-6), restricting access to what each role requires.

3.3.3 Cross-Border Data Transfer Governance

To handle the clash between the EU GDPR's strict transfer rules and Nepal's proposed data localization requirements under the IT Bill 2024, the organization will take a hybrid approach:

- **Data Localization (Nepal):** Sensitive citizen data in Nepal will be stored within the country to comply with upcoming local data protection requirements.
- **Standard Contractual Clauses (SCCs):** When data needs to be transferred from the EU/UK to Nepal or other countries, the institution will use approved SCCs to ensure the receiving party offers protection equivalent to GDPR standards.

3.3.4 Incident Reporting and Management

- **Mandatory Reporting:** Report any suspected incident to the SOC immediately.
- **Regulatory Notification:** Notify relevant authorities (like the ICO in the UK or Nepal's proposed NCSC) within 72 hours of a data breach, per GDPR and Nepal's emerging standards.

3.3.5 Role-Specific Ethical Guidelines

To ensure accountability, specific duties are mapped to framework clauses:

Role	Ethical Duty & Responsibility	Framework Mapping
SOC Analyst	Duty of Confidentiality and Integrity: System should be monitored fairly, without bias, and only within authorized	NIST CSF (DE.CM): Anomalies and Events are detected in a timely manner

	limits to protect employee privacy.	
Chief Information Security Officer (CISO)	Transparency & Risk Communication: Must give the Board an honest picture of the organization's risk level. Can't hide vulnerabilities or delay breach reporting to protect status.	ISO/IEC 27001 (Clause 5): Leadership's role in the security management system.
IT Auditor	Independence & Objectivity: Must audit free from management influence and report findings honestly even flagging non-compliance with data minimization or least privilege, despite any friction it causes.	COBIT 2019 (MEA02): Ensures independent assurance through managed internal controls.

Task 4: Professional Portfolio, Ethical Identity, and Reflective Growth

4.2 Three Critical Competencies for Cybersecurity Professionals

4.2.1 Competency 1: Cyber Threat Intelligence Analysis

The ability to gather, process, analyze, and share useful intelligence on current and emerging cyber threats. This involves understanding how attackers operate, assessing their capabilities, and predicting likely attack method to build stringer cybersecurity defenses.

Evidence of Development:

My understanding of cyber threat intelligence has considerably enhanced after studying this module. I discovered that CTI is not only concerned with responding

to incidents after they occur but also with preventing them in the first place. The cases involving Equifax breach and Colonial Pipeline ransomware attack instructed me the importance of collection and analyzing threat intelligence, patching, and vulnerability assessment. Moreover, I got familiar with different open-source intelligence tools for detecting cyber threats.

Growth Plan:

1. **Complete a Certification:** Earn a certification like **CompTIA CySA+** to build strong threat intelligence skills and gain industry identification.
2. **Join Cybersecurity Communities:** Take part in online cybersecurity groups, follow threat intelligence experts, and learn about the latest cyber threats.
3. **Practice with Real Scenarios:** Build practical cybersecurity skills through hands-on labs, malware and phishing analysis, and incident response exercise in synthetic environments.

4.2.2 Competency 2: Ethical Decision-Making in Cybersecurity

Description: The ability to identify, evaluate, and address ethical challenges in cybersecurity while balancing security, privacy, individual rights, and the broader impact on society. It also involves following ethical principles and professional standards when making decisions.

Evidence of Development:

This module strengthened my understanding of cybersecurity ethics by teaching me how to balance security with privacy, make informed decision about security measures, and consider ethical issues in leadership and risk management. It also helped me appreciate the human side of cybersecurity and impact that security decisions can have on individuals and society.

Growth Plan:

1. **Learn Ethical Guidelines:** Regularly explore ethical framework and apply them to cybersecurity scenarios to strength my decision-making skills.
2. **Join Ethics Discussions:** Take part in workshops, or discussions to learn different views on cybersecurity ethics.

3. Follow a Personal Code of Ethics: Develop and follow a personal code of ethics on professional standards to guide my decision and actions in cybersecurity.

4.2.3 Competency 3: Policy Development and Implementation

Description: The ability to turn legal and ethical requirements into clear cybersecurity policies and procedures that support an organization's goals and meet legal regulations. It also involves working with stakeholders and regularly updating policies to keep them effective.

Evidence of Development:

Through this module, I learned how cybersecurity laws and regulations help organizations create effective security policies. Studying Nepal's ETA 2063, the proposed IT Bill 2024, the UK DPA 2018, and GDPR helped me understand different legal requirements. I also learned how to develop cybersecurity policies using framework such as NIST CSF, ISO 27001, and COBIT. Overall, I gained practical skills in certain security policies, identifying gaps, and helping industries meet legal and cybersecurity requirements.

Growth Plan:

- 1. Learn Security Frameworks:** Study frameworks like **ISO 27001**, **NIST CSF**, and **COBIT** to strengthen my understanding of how cybersecurity policies are developed and managed.
- 2. Practice Writing Policies:** Build practical experience by developing or improving cybersecurity policies and procedures through real-world projects or workplace environments.
- 3. Understand Compliance:** Develop a better understanding of how security policies are reviewed, audited, and implemented to ensure compliance with legal organization requirements.

4.3 Ethical Identity and Professional Reputation

This module helped me become a more ethical cybersecurity professional by teaching me the importance of acting responsibly, being honest with stakeholders, and maintaining privacy and clear when responding to ethical or security incidents. By comparing the cases of Microsoft and Equifax, it becomes

obvious how being ethical and honest can help companies manage the aftermath of security problems.

Conclusion

Overall, this report demonstrated that the key to the success of cybersecurity is not only technical, but also legal, ethical, and leadership skills. The role of modern cyber laws was emphasized by the comparison with UK, and the ethical discussion revealed the need to strike a balance between security and fairness and privacy. The three case studies of Equifax, Colonial Pipeline, and Microsoft showed how leadership and transparency are vital during the cyber incident. Finally, this module strengthened my knowledge of threat intelligence, ethical decision-making, and cybersecurity policy development, preparing me to become a responsible and effective cybersecurity professional.

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GitHub

<https://github.com/csah45564-debug/The-Ethics-And-Legal-Framework-Of-Cyber-Security.git>